

LIBRARY LESSON PLAN

Harlem Renaissance Library Session

Grades 6–8 · 45 minutes · Research + critical analysis

THE 45 MINUTES

5 min	5 min	28 min	7 min
PROVOCATION	RESEARCH FRAME	RESEARCH AND ACTIVITY CARDS	SHARE

SESSION GOALS

What students will do

Students will: conduct targeted research using library resources and the exhibition; evaluate and compare primary and secondary sources; develop and defend an interpretive claim about the Harlem Renaissance; and practice evidence-based writing. The librarian connects information literacy skills explicitly to the historical inquiry.

PREPARATION

- **Pull and display:** 10–12 library books across biography, poetry collections, history, and critical essays (see page 2)
- Set up 3 research stations with specific books and a guiding question card at each (optional — see station suggestions, page 2)
- **Tables set:** differentiated activity cards, pencils; computers/iPads available for Red-level independent research
- **Project:** one Douglas image for reference during the session

SESSION FLOW

0–5 MIN Opening provocation	Show two images side by side — Aaron Douglas's *Song of the Towers* and the Obelisk/Reconstruction mural. No labels. Ask: *"What is different about these two paintings — and what does the difference tell you?"* Take 4–5 responses. Then: *"Both were made by the same man, in the same decade, in Harlem. Today you're going to figure out why they look so different."*
5–10 MIN Research skills frame	Briefly introduce the session structure. Model: how to use an index efficiently; what a primary source vs. secondary source looks like; how to take a note without copying word-for-word. Remind: *"Your job is not to collect facts. Your job is to build an argument."*
10–38 MIN Research and activity cards	Students work on differentiated cards, using library resources. Red-level students have independent research tasks requiring catalog use. Circulate: challenge students to show you one piece of evidence and explain how it supports their argument. Push for analytical writing, not summary.
38–45 MIN Share and synthesis	One Yellow student and one Red student share their argument/claim. Class responds: *"Do you agree? What evidence would you add or challenge?"* Close with: *"Everything you found today was already in this building. The library is the archive of human thought — and the Harlem Renaissance is part of that archive."*

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the Exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more.

Option 2 — Virtual Visit:

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

BOOK RECOMMENDATIONS · GRADES 6–8

HISTORY AND BIOGRAPHY

The Warmth of Other Suns — Isabel Wilkerson — the definitive Great Migration account (National Book Critics Circle Award); excerpts suitable for Grades 7–8

Up From Slavery — Booker T. Washington — important context; free online

The Souls of Black Folk — W.E.B. Du Bois — foundational text; excerpts appropriate for advanced Grade 8

Harlem Stomp! — Laban Carrick Hill — age-appropriate history with primary source excerpts

Zora Neale Hurston: A Life in Letters — edited by Carla Kaplan — primary sources

POETRY AND LITERATURE

The Collected Poems of Langston Hughes — complete; ideal for class copies

Their Eyes Were Watching God — Zora Neale Hurston — Grade 8+ excerpt-level; full novel for strong readers

The New Negro — ed. Alain Locke (1925) — the defining anthology of the Renaissance; free online via HathiTrust

If We Must Die: The Life of Claude McKay — Gary Edward Holcomb

poetryfoundation.org and poets.org — many Renaissance-era poems free, with teaching notes

OPTIONAL RESEARCH STATION CARDS

01

Station A — The Poets

Find two poems by different Harlem Renaissance poets. What do they have in common? What is different about their voices and arguments?

02

Station B — The Painters

Research Aaron Douglas and Jacob Lawrence. Both used bold, flat shapes. How are their styles different? What was each trying to say?

03

Station C — The Context

Find one fact about what life was like for Black Americans in the South before the Great Migration. Find one fact about what they found in the North. Does the data change your understanding of the Harlem Renaissance?

INFORMATION LITERACY CONNECTIONS

- **Database vs. book:** Show students how Britannica School or JSTOR Kids yields different results from a library book — different types of sources for different tasks
- **Citation:** Red-level students should cite at least one source in their response — introduce MLA or Chicago author-date as appropriate for grade level
- **Search strategy:** Teach subject heading searching in the catalog: “Harlem Renaissance,” “African American art — 20th century,” “Jazz — history and criticism”

Paintings to project (in copyright, so not printed; each title links to the museum’s page): Aspects of Negro Life: From Slavery Through Reconstruction (1934) · Aspects of Negro Life: Song of the Towers (1934)